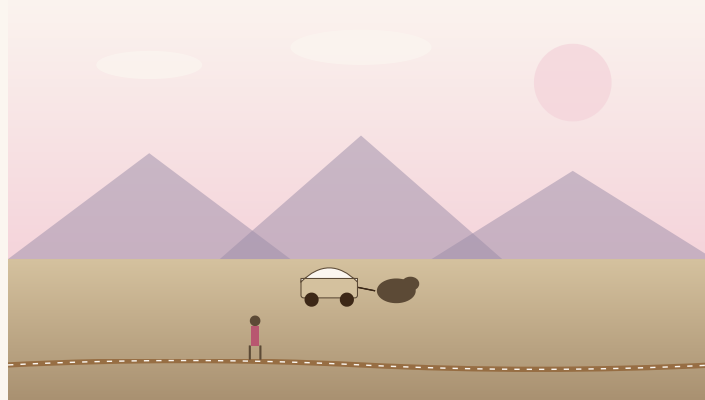


Pink Oregon Trail

A game of westward journey · 1848



Welcome, pioneer. The year is 1848. Your wagon train sets out from Independence, Missouri for Oregon City — 2,000 miles away across plains, mountains, deserts, and rivers. You will choose seven brave souls to come with you. You will face cholera, bandits, river crossings, and weather. Some of you may not make it. But those who do will see the Pacific.

What you'll learn

The Oregon Trail is the most famous overland migration in American history. Between 1840 and 1860, between 300,000 and 500,000 people walked west on this trail. About one in ten died along the way. This game lets you experience their journey — the choices they faced, the hardships they endured, and the ingenuity that helped them survive.

What's in the box

- **The game board** — a foldable map of the trail, with 25 stops (Short Journey) or 50 stops (Extended Journey)
- **Wagon tokens** — one per team, to mark your position on the board
- **The game itself** — opens in any web browser, no internet required
- **This rules booklet** — what you're reading now

Designed by Gabby Kasdaglis — for her sixth-grade history class · v3.4.1

Setting Out

Setup — about 5 minutes

Step 1 — Open the game

Double-click **pink_oregon_trail.html** on your computer. The game opens in any web browser. No internet required. The game will run from a USB drive if you don't have it on the school computer.

Step 2 — Choose your difficulty



Easy

Forgiving trail. More money. One revival.



Medium

The honest trail. Recommended for most plays.



Hard

Trail of Tears. Cholera spreads. The land is unforgiving.

Step 3 — Choose your mode

- **Single Player** — one driver, one wagon, one journey
- **Cooperative** — everyone shares one wagon and decides together. Best for first plays.
- **Competitive** — 2-4 wagons race west. First to Oregon wins (but survival matters more than speed).

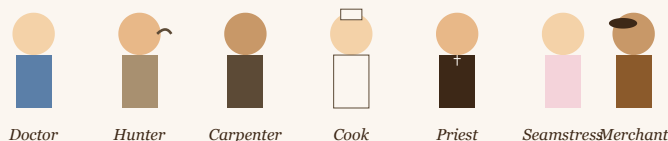
Step 4 — Choose your trail length

- **Short Journey** — 25 stops, about 15 minutes — fits a class period
- **Extended Journey** — 50 stops, about 40 minutes — the full crossing

Step 5 — Outfit at Independence (new in v3.4)

Before you leave, you'll spend money on three things: a **wagon**, an **animal team**, and up to **two heirlooms** from home. Every dollar spent here is a dollar you won't have at the forts. The full menu is on Page 3 of this booklet.

Step 6 — Build your team of seven



Seven travelers — different skills, different stories

You will see **23 people** who want to come west, sorted alphabetically. Pick exactly seven. Each one brings a skill. The Doctor heals the sick. The Hunter brings food. The Carpenter fixes the wagon. The Priest holds the team's faith. **Choose carefully — once you're on the trail, you can't recruit more.**

Step 7 — Name them

Give each of the seven a name. Real names — your family, your friends, your favorite characters. They will appear in your story when the journey is done. The trail remembers.

♦ **Tip:** *First time playing? Pick the Doctor and the Hunter for sure. The others are up to you.*

Outfitting at Independence

Three decisions before you leave — every dollar spent here is a dollar you won't have at the forts

Your starting purse is **\$160 (Easy)**, **\$130 (Medium)**, or **\$110 (Hard)**. The maximum loadout costs \$110 — pick everything and you arrive at the trail nearly broke. Pick the cheap options and you ride out with money to spend at forts. The trade-off is real. There is no right answer.

1. Pick a wagon

- **Plain Farm Wagon** — **\$0**. 75 starting condition. Cheap, light, but breaks more often. Saves money for food and medicine.
- **Prairie Schooner** — **\$25**. 100 starting condition. Hickory bows, canvas top, iron-tired wheels. The trusted choice — most pioneers picked this.
- **Reinforced Schooner** — **\$50**. 100 starting condition + 5% river-drown reduction + 10% wagon-damage escape. Expensive but durable. Less to spend on food, but the wagon will hold.

2. Pick an animal team

- **Four Oxen** — **\$0**. Slow, strong, calm. Eat prairie grass. The trusted choice.
- **Two Oxen + Two Mules** — **\$30**. A bit faster (+1 to dice rolls), tougher than horses. Slightly easier for thieves to spot.
- **Four Horses** — **\$60**. Fastest team (+2 to dice rolls). Need grain, get sick more easily, and are more often stolen.

3. Pick up to two heirlooms (or none)

Pioneers had to leave most of their possessions behind. The heirloom you bring is the one that matters most — but every choice has a possible cost and a possible reward.

- **Family Bible**. Light. A quiet comfort on hard nights — pioneers said reading aloud held a wagon together.
- **Grandmother's China**. Fragile. River crossings are unkind to china — but a real set of plates made a cabin feel like home, and good china traded well at fort sutlers.
- **Father's Tools**. Heavy. River crossings risk losing them. A real carpenter's chest patches the wagon on the road and builds the first cabin in Oregon.
- **A Trunk of Books**. Light. Children read aloud at the campfire — they may catch a fact that saves the wagon at trail's end.
- **The Family Piano**. Very heavy. Disaster at the ford if the wagon tips. But a piano makes the camp something other than a camp — there are stories of music breaking a fever in the small hours.
- **Family Photographs**. Light. After two thousand miles of strangers, they remind everyone who they are. A quiet morale lift the day you reach Oregon.
- **A Bag of Seeds**. Light. The first crop in Oregon was worth more than a season of wages — bring seed and you arrive with a future, not just a wagon.
- **Wedding Silver**. Heavy. Bandits and bored fort sutlers both notice silver. But it sells in Oregon for far more than it cost back home.

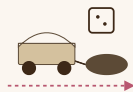
◆ **Tip:** *First time picking? Schooner + Oxen + Bible + Books is a balanced, safe loadout. Want a riskier story? Reinforced Schooner + Horses + Piano + Silver — costly, fast, dramatic.*

A Turn at a Time

How to play — every turn, every choice

Each turn, your team picks ONE of four actions. Then the day passes. Then something happens — sometimes ordinary, sometimes not.

The Four Actions



Push On

Roll the dice and travel west. The default action — most turns will be Push On.



Hunt

Spend the day hunting. Brings food, and a hide if you have a Hunter or Trapper.



Rest

Make camp. Heals weakened and sick members. Costs a day of travel.



Forage

Search for berries, plants, and water. Slower than hunting but works in any region.

What happens after you choose

1. **The dice roll.** If you Push On, dice decide how far you travel that day.
2. **The day passes.** Your team eats food, drinks water, uses supplies. Numbers tick down.
3. **Something happens.** The new space might be a fort, a river, a landmark, or just open trail. Often, an event happens — a storm, a stranger, a chance encounter. Choose how to respond.
4. **The next day begins.**

The four actions repeat every turn. Push On is the default — you'll do it most days. Hunt when you're low on food and have plenty of time. Rest when someone is sick and you're safe. Forage when you can't decide between Hunt and Rest.

v3.4 reminder: Look at the **top-left of the screen**. After the day and date, you'll see "*Spot N of M — [Name]*". That tells you exactly where your wagon is at all times — match it to the printed board's spot N.

Watching Your Team

Resources, health, and what the colors mean

The Resource Ribbon (top of screen)

							
Food (lbs) ~2 lbs/person/day. Cook reduces 22%.	Water (gal) 0.5 gal/person/day.	Supplies Rope, oil, tools — used in repairs.	Medicine (doses) Sickness without it can kill. Doctor uses less per cure.	Hides Sell at forts (\$3 each).	Money (\$) Dollars and cents. Pays for everything at forts.	Wagon Condition 0-100. Damage from rivers and miles reduces it. Forts repair for \$8 / 2 supplies.	Morale Team spirit (0- 10).

Starting purse and daily money depletion (v3.4)

Your starting purse depends on difficulty: **\$160 (Easy)**, **\$130 (Medium)**, **\$110 (Hard)**. Whatever's left after the loadout is your trail money. Every day you Push On the trail bleeds a small amount for tolls, oxen feed, mending, and barter — about **\$0.10 per living member per day** on Medium. A 7-person Medium team loses roughly \$0.70 a day to the trail. It's not stagnant. Watch the purse.

Prices at forts (Medium difficulty, before Merchant discount)

- **Food** — \$0.22 per pound
- **Water** — \$0.18 per gallon
- **Medicine** — \$6.00 per dose
- **Supplies** — \$2.40 per unit
- **Wagon repair** — \$8.00 (restores 35 condition; +1 day) or 2 supplies if no money
- **Major repair (broken axle)** — \$18.00 (restores 50)
- **Ferry crossing** — \$8.00 (\$5.00 with a Merchant)
- **Local guide** — \$7.00 (avoids the next "lost trail")
- **Visit fort doctor** — \$9.00 (only when a member is dying; +50% revival chance)
- **Send a letter home** — \$2.00 (+2 morale)
- **Get trail news** — \$3.00 (sutler shares hazards and routes ahead)

A **Merchant** on the team buys at -15% and sells at +40%.

Unexpected costs

- Food spoils. Water spills. Wheels crack. About one unexpected event per 4-5 days of travel.
- A **Cook** halves food spoilage; a **Blacksmith** reduces wagon damage; a **Carpenter** rebuilds broken axles for free; a **Guide** or **Scout** may avoid the day's mishap altogether.
- Without medicine, sickness kills.

How to get more of each:

- **Food:** Hunt (+22 lbs, Hunter), trap (+12 lbs, Trapper), forage (+10 lbs, Farmer), buy at forts, certain events
- **Water:** Cross rivers, forage, buy at forts, certain events
- **Supplies:** Buy at forts, certain events
- **Medicine:** Buy at forts (\$6.00/dose); a Doctor on team starts with +1 dose

- **Hides:** Successful hunts (more if Hunter or Trapper on team)
- **Money:** Sell hides at forts, sell extra food/water/supplies, day labor at forts, profession-specific encounter events, discovered caches; a Banker on team starts with +\$12
- **Wagon Condition:** Repair at fort (\$8 / \$18), or free with a Carpenter on team
- **Morale:** Rest, send a letter home, certain events, eating well

The Team Strip (bottom of screen)

Your seven team members appear in a row at the bottom. Below each name is a small **health bar** that tells you how they're doing.



When a team member's health bar turns gold or orange, act. Rest. Buy food. Find a Doctor. If you wait until red, you may run out of time. The game will warn you — but you have to listen.

When someone falls ill (new in v3.4)

The moment a team member transitions to *sick*, *injured*, or *dying*, the game pauses and shows you their **daily survival chance** as a percentage. You then choose:

- **Use a dose of medicine on them.** Lifts them one tier — sick to weakened, weakened to healthy. The screen shows the new survival percentage before you commit.
- **Save the medicine — don't treat anyone right now.** The dose stays in the wagon. The ill member's daily survival stays the same; food, water, rest, and morale all still help.
- **Use the dose on a different ailing member.** Triage option — the screen lists every unwell teammate with their before/after percentages so you can pick.

If someone is dying

If a member reaches *dying* state, an additional intervention modal appears with five choices:

- **Race to a fort** for medical help — costs a day, +30% chance to save them. Hidden when you're already at one.
- **Visit the fort doctor** — \$9.00, only available when the wagon is currently at a fort. Strong odds (+50%) and no day lost.
- **Stop and tend to them** — costs 2 days, doubled with a Doctor on team
- **Pray and continue** — slower, requires a Priest for best chance
- **Continue at full pace** — last resort, riskiest
- **Use a Revival** (Easy mode only — once per game)

♦ **Tip:** *A Doctor on your team can save sick and dying members — but only if the Doctor is healthy themselves. Protect your protectors.*

Special Situations

Rivers, forts, weather, bandits, and history

Crossing rivers

You will cross many rivers. Each time, you have four choices:



Ford

Walk through. Free but risky if deep.



Caulk

Seal wagon and float. Can damage supplies.



Ferry

Pay \$8 (\$5 with Merchant). Safest option.



Native Guide

Local guide leads you safely. Better with Language Teacher.

Stopping at forts

Forts are critical. At any fort you can:

- **Buy supplies** — Money for food/water/supplies
- **Sell goods** — Hides and excess become Money
- **Hire on for the day** — Earn money but lose travel time
- **Repair wagon** — \$8 (or 2 supplies) restores +35 Wagon Condition, costs 1 day. Carpenter does it free and full.
- **Rest** — Spend a day. Heals team. Boosts morale.
- **Get trail news** — See what's coming up next
- **Send a letter home** — 1 Money, +2 Morale, write to family
- **Move on** — Skip the fort and keep going

Storms, animals, and chance

The trail is unpredictable. Storms hit. Wolves circle the camp. A friendly Native family might trade with you. A traveling preacher might bless your journey. A gold prospector might pass through. You'll see a "Something Unexpected" banner when surprise events happen — listen carefully and choose well.

The bandit ambush

Near the end of the trail, you will be ambushed by bandits. Your team will face **3 to 7 multiple-choice questions** (depending on difficulty) drawn from historical facts the game showed you along the journey. Pay attention to the Did You Know cards — that's how you win this fight. Get most right, and the bandits ride away. Get most wrong, and you'll lose people and supplies.

Historical landmarks

Special places along the trail (Independence Rock, Chimney Rock, Soda Springs, Fort Laramie, Alcove Spring, The Dalles) have **real historical pictures and facts**. These are real places real pioneers passed by. Look at the picture. Read the fact. The bandit quiz will be drawn from these.

Reading the in-game map (v3.4)

To keep the trail readable, only the **major anchors** get on-canvas labels: forts, the start, and the finish. Every other roundel — landmarks, rivers, travel spots — shows its name when you **hover over the dot**. Each major roundel also has the step number printed inside, and the calendar bar at the top of the screen always tells you exactly which spot you're on.

All teams now end in Oregon City. The California fork (Hastings Cutoff) is no longer offered.

Winning the Trail

Strategy and the spirit of the game

How to win

Reach Oregon City — Stop 25 (Short) or Stop 50 (Extended) — before winter snows close the mountain passes (Day 165). The more team members alive when you arrive, the higher your score.

Scoring — Four kinds of winning (v3.3)

A trail is not won or lost in a single number. There are four tracks, and your team's total is the sum of all four.

- **Steward** (up to 280 pts) — Members alive $\times$ average health $\times$ average morale $\times$ 4. Reward for bringing your people through.
- **Provider** (up to 150 pts) — Money $\times$ 2 + food + water + medicine doses $\times$ 5. Reward for a wagon still well-stocked at the end.
- **Scholar** (up to 170 pts) — DYK cards seen $\times$ 5 + bandit quiz right answers $\times$ 10. Reward for paying attention to the trail's history.
- **Pathfinder** (up to 80 pts) — $\max(0, 110 - \text{days traveled})$. Reward for racing the winter clock.

A team finishing slow with everyone alive at full pantries beats a team finishing fast with empty pantries and lost people, by more than 2 $\times$. That's the lesson the trail teaches.

A legacy single-number score is also kept for the historical leaderboard — you'll see both at the end.

Five strategic principles

1. Watch the warning bars. When a team member's health bar drops to gold, act. The game gives you windows — use them.

2. Hides become money. Hunt regularly with a Hunter or Trapper. Sell hides at every fort. Cash flow lets you buy ferries instead of risking river crossings, send letters home, and stock up for hard regions.

3. Rations matter. Bare Bones rations save food but weaken your team — only safe in short bursts. Filling rations heal but burn fast — use after hunts. Meager is the default.

4. Pace matters. Steady is sustainable. Strenuous gets you there faster but tires the team. Grueling is for

emergencies only — sustained Grueling pace will collapse your wagon.

5. Pay attention to history. Every Did You Know card might appear in the bandit quiz at the end. The kids who pay attention to the trail win the trail.

What makes a great wagon

Not the one that arrives fastest. Not the one with all seven members alive. The one whose journey was **worth telling** — the team that made hard choices, lost good people, learned from forts, traded with strangers, and arrived in Oregon with a story.

After the journey, the game will write you a **Trail Journal** — a multi-paragraph period-voice story of your specific wagon's specific journey. Print it out. Keep it. Read it back to your class.



One last thing

Real pioneers were not just men with rifles. **One in five was a child.** About half were women. Many were Black, Mexican, or Native American. They came from every faith and every state. They fought, helped, married, mourned, and kept walking. The trail is their story.

This game is yours now. Walk it well.

*Pink Oregon Trail — designed by Gabby Kasdaglis, with her father
For her sixth-grade history class, 2026*



New in Version 3.3

Strategy, depth, and the four kinds of winning

The trail tires you out

If your wagon Pushes On day after day without stopping to Hunt, Rest, or Forage, the trail itself starts to push back. The lead ox refuses to move. Someone in the camp falls ill. The wagon's bones loosen. Eventually a major breakdown halts you for two days.

You won't see a meter for this — kids should feel the strain, not stare at a number. The cure is simple: stop sometimes. Hunt resets the counter. So does Rest. So does Forage.

Stopping at forts matters

If you pass a fort with a sick team member, you'll feel it for the next three days — your team is more likely to get worse. If you pass with low food, your morale drops. If you pass with a tired wagon, the next damage event hits 1.5× harder. There is no rule that you must stop. There is just a trail that pays attention.

Each member is an individual

Every member of your wagon now carries five hidden traits: *Bold or Cautious, Frail or Hardy, Faithful or Doubtful, Steady or Restless, Lucky or Star-crossed*. You'll see the descriptors on the character card. A Frail member catches cholera more easily. A Steady Hunter feeds the team more reliably. The trail still rolls dice — but who the dice fall on isn't random.

More to encounter, more to remember

- **40 historical facts** in the trail's Did You Know pool (was 23). The bandit quiz at the end can ask any of them — and now most facts have **2 to 3 phrasings**, so playing the same fort twice doesn't show the same questions.
- **25 daily calamities** (was 11). Lightning, hailstorms, snake bites, sunstroke, gun accidents, prairie fires, buffalo stampedes, tornadoes, quicksand, lost children, ferry rope snaps, powder keg explosions, tooth abscesses. Each with three different ways the story might unfold.
- **40 fortunes** (was 16). Native trades for salmon and horses, mountain men with maps, fellow emigrants sharing tools, bumper buffalo herds, mild summers, babies born on the trail, rainbows over Independence Rock. Real pioneers had luck too.

What the trail teaches

The Aurora Borealis is beautiful. White Buffalo sightings are sacred to the Lakota and Cheyenne. Falling stars are the Leonid meteor shower. The new **Did You Know** pairings explain what people saw without claiming what it meant. Kids draw their own conclusions.

The "What You Learned" page

At the end of every journey, a new printable page replaces the old single-page scoreboard. Six sections:

1. **Your Trail in Numbers** — the four scoring tracks side by side
2. **What History You Met** — every DYK card your team saw
3. **The Choices You Made** — your forks in the road, with what historians say
4. **The People You Lost (or Saved)** — name, profession, status, epitaph
5. **Discussion Questions for Your Teacher** — five auto-generated for your specific journey
6. **Standards Demonstrated** — the FL benchmarks the journey covered

The Trail Journal is still there — click "Read the Trail Journal" at the bottom to expand it.

For teachers: Turn on Teacher Mode at setup and enter a Class Session ID. Every wagon that uses the same ID feeds into one printable **Class Dashboard** at the end — Standards Coverage, Class Heatmap (which facts everyone saw and which nobody did), Aggregate Decisions, Aggregate Outcomes, and Discussion Prompts. The class becomes its own wagon train.

The new map

Tap or click the mini-map to expand it. Now you can pinch to zoom, drag to pan, scroll to zoom on a laptop, or press the floating ⊕ button to center on your wagon at 2.5× zoom. The scale readout at the bottom-left tells you how many miles per inch at your current zoom. Place names stay readable at every zoom level.



Pink Oregon Trail v3.3 — for Gabby's classroom and beyond

How Wagons Generally Do

Average team-completion rates by difficulty and trail length

These numbers come from running each game configuration five hundred times and averaging the results. They show how often a wagon reaches Oregon City. The two reference teams below bracket the range — your team will fall somewhere between, depending on how you play and which professions you pick.

Strong team = a wagon with a Hunter (brings food) AND a Doctor (saves people from cholera). The trail rewards preparation.

Weak team = a wagon with neither of those professions. They can still win, but more is up to luck.

Short Journey (25 stops, about 15-20 minutes)

Difficulty	Strong team finishes	Weak team finishes	Historical year
Easy — Forgiving Trail	~95-98%	~75-85%	<i>A mild year (1841-43)</i>
Medium — Honest Trail	~80-88%	~35-45%	<i>1849, the standard year</i>
Hard — Trail of Tears	~60-68%	~10-15%	<i>A bad year (1852 cholera)</i>

Extended Journey (50 stops, about 35-50 minutes)

Difficulty	Strong team finishes	Weak team finishes	Historical year
Easy — Forgiving Trail	~94-98%	~58-66%	<i>A mild year (1841-43)</i>
Medium — Honest Trail	~70-77%	~14-20%	<i>1849, the standard year</i>
Hard — Trail of Tears	~38-43%	~1-5%	<i>A bad year (1852 cholera)</i>

What this means

About one in ten emigrants died on the historical Oregon Trail. That number was higher in bad years and lower in good ones. Pink Oregon Trail tries to honor that by making the game truly difficult on Hard, fair on Medium, and forgiving on Easy.

If your wagon is a strong team and you play carefully, you should finish often. If your wagon is a weak team or you play recklessly, sometimes the trail will take you. That is the trail's lesson, and it is the same lesson the real pioneers learned.

For first-timers: start on Easy / Short. You will likely make it through and learn the rhythm of the game in fifteen minutes.

For repeat players: Medium / Extended is the historically honest experience — about one in five wagons may not finish, and the journey takes about forty-five minutes.

For confident players: Hard / Extended is for kids who want a real test. About half the wagons fail. The trail is unforgiving in 1852.

A note on professions: even an "unexpected" profession sometimes makes the difference. A Musician who keeps morale up across a hard week, an Artist whose sketches lift the team's spirits, a Banker whose extra coin pays the Barlow toll — every team member can be the reason the wagon finishes. Strategy matters, and so does luck, and so does the people you bring.

